

UNIT 1 | UPSC SOCIOLOGY OPTIONAL Part A

MODERNITY, SOCIAL CHANGE IN EUROPE AND EMERGENCE OF SOCIOLOGY

MODERNITY • SOCIAL CHANGE • EMERGENCE OF SOCIOLOGY

BY- DEEPAK K SINGH

What is Modernity?

Modernity means the wide-ranging social, economic, political, intellectual and cultural changes through which European society moved away from the old traditional-feudal order and developed the modern society. It was not a single event. It was a long process in which the economy, political institutions, family, religion, knowledge and everyday life were reorganised.

In simple words, modernity begins when people stop accepting an arrangement only because it is old and begin to ask whether it is rational, useful, just and capable of improvement.

The major transitions associated with modernity

- **Tradition → Rationality:** In a traditional setting, a practice is often defended by saying, “This is how our ancestors did it.” Modernity gives greater importance to reason, evidence and calculation. A public authority may change a rule after a scientific study instead of preserving it only because it is customary. **Example:** Decisions about vaccination or city drainage are expected to be based on medical evidence and public data.
- **Feudalism → Capitalism:** Under feudalism, land and hereditary obligations were central. Capitalism reorganised production around private investment, markets, profit and wage labour.

Example: A person in a feudal manor was tied to the land and to a lord, whereas a worker in a modern factory sells labour for a wage and the factory owner invests capital to earn profit.

- **Agrarian economy → Industrial economy:** Economic life shifted from dependence mainly on agriculture to dependence on factories, machines and large-scale production. **Example:** A town that earlier depended on hand-spinning and farming may become a textile-manufacturing centre employing thousands of factory workers.
- **Status by birth → Achievement and class:** A person's position was no longer explained only by birth or estate. Education, occupation, skill and income became important. **Example:** A person from a modest family can become a doctor through education. At the same time, modern society does not automatically remove inherited inequality because family wealth and cultural capital still affect opportunity.
- **Religious authority → Secular-rational authority:** Religion remained important for many people, but law and administration increasingly claimed an independent basis. **Example:** A modern court decides a property dispute through a legal code and constitutional principles rather than only through the religious status of the parties.
- **Monarchy → Nation-state and mass democracy:** Political legitimacy gradually moved away from the divine right of kings towards citizenship, popular sovereignty, elections and constitutional government. **Example:** A citizen chooses representatives through voting instead of being treated only as a subject of a hereditary monarch.
- **Local economy → Market economy:** Production and exchange became connected across regions and countries. Relationships became more impersonal because buyers and sellers often did not know one another personally. **Example:** A farmer may sell produce through a national market and purchase seeds from a company located in another state.
- **Community-centred life → Increasing individualism:** Individuals acquired greater importance as holders of rights and as decision-makers. They could increasingly choose education, occupation and residence. **Example:** A young person may move to another city for a career rather than follow the occupation of the family. The same process can also create loneliness and weaker community bonds.
- **Past-oriented society → Future/progress-oriented society:** Modern societies commonly believe that planned change, science and reform can produce a better future. **Example:** A government prepares a long-term plan for renewable energy and public transport instead of assuming that present arrangements must continue forever.

Philosophical modernity therefore involved a break from traditional modes of production, movement towards a **market economy, nation-state and mass democracy**, and a growing orientation towards the future rather than the past.

Simple sociological meaning

Modernity replaces the unquestioned sentence:

“Things are this way because they have always been this way.”

with the questions:

“Why is society organised this way?” and “Can it be changed?”

For example, poverty was once often treated as a personal failure or fate. Modern sociology asks how wages, property, education, discrimination and labour institutions may produce or reproduce poverty.

Core sociological argument

Sociology did not emerge merely because a few intellectuals suddenly became curious about society. It emerged because European society itself experienced an unprecedented structural transformation. This transformation created urgent problems of:

- **Order:** If the old church, monarchy and feudal ties weaken, what will hold society together? **Example:** After a revolution, people need new rules and institutions to prevent violence and uncertainty.
- **Change:** Why are institutions changing so rapidly? **Example:** Factory work and urban migration changed the rhythm of family life within a few generations.
- **Conflict:** Why do different classes and groups have opposed interests? **Example:** Factory owners wanted profit while workers demanded better wages and safer conditions.
- **Inequality:** Why does new wealth coexist with deep poverty? **Example:** Industrial cities produced rich owners as well as poorly paid workers living in crowded housing.
- **Integration:** How can people who are different in occupation, religion and background live together? **Example:** A modern city has to integrate migrants, professionals, labourers and different communities through common institutions.

Thus, sociology became an intellectual response to the movement from traditional society to modern society.

Why Sociology is Closely Connected with Modernity

Sociology has a long intellectual pre-history but a relatively short history as an independent discipline. Human beings have always discussed social life, but they did not always study it through a separate, systematic discipline.

- **Plato** discussed justice, education and the ideal organisation of the state. His discussion is an intellectual antecedent because it asks how society should be organised, but it is mainly philosophical and normative. **Example:** Plato's ideal state is an argument about the kind of social order that ought to exist.
- **Aristotle** examined the household, citizenship, constitutions and political communities. His work shows careful observation, but it was not sociology in the modern empirical sense. **Example:** His classification of forms of government helps us think about political institutions, although it was not based on modern social surveys.

These ancient discussions were largely philosophical, normative and speculative. They asked what a good society ought to be, what justice means or what the ideal state should look like. Sociology later asked more directly how actual societies work, how institutions affect behaviour and how social patterns can be studied through evidence.

During medieval Europe, explanations of social reality were strongly influenced by theology, the Church, tradition and divine authority. If a social hierarchy existed, it was often explained as part of a divinely ordained order. **Example:** The unequal position of different estates could be presented as natural and religiously sanctioned rather than as a human arrangement open to change.

Sociology became possible when society began to be seen as an independent reality that could be studied systematically and scientifically. This did not mean that religion disappeared. It meant that social institutions could also be explained through their own historical, economic and political conditions.

Example: Instead of explaining urban poverty only as a moral defect of the poor, a sociologist studies wages, housing, migration, labour markets and public policy.

Medieval European Society: The Starting Point

Medieval European society provides the background against which modernity can be understood. It was not completely static, but its main institutions gave an appearance of stability and continuity.

- **Feudalism:** Land was the major source of power. Lords controlled land and peasants or serfs worked on it in return for protection and customary rights. **Example:** A peasant living on a manor could be obliged to provide labour or a part of the produce to the feudal lord.
- **Dominance of the Church:** The Church influenced education, morality, law and public life. Religious explanations were often treated as the highest authority. **Example:** A dispute about moral conduct could be judged through religious teaching rather than through an independent secular legal system.

- **Monarchy:** Political authority was concentrated in kings and hereditary rulers. Ordinary people had limited participation in decision-making. **Example:** A person was born a subject of a king and had no regular mechanism to choose the ruler.
- **Hereditary social hierarchy:** Social status was strongly connected with birth and estate. Nobility, clergy, peasants and artisans occupied different positions. **Example:** The child of a noble family had privileges that were generally unavailable to a peasant even when the peasant was capable and hardworking.
- **Limited mobility:** Movement from one social position to another was difficult because occupations, land rights and privileges were inherited. **Example:** A person born into a peasant family would usually remain a peasant.
- **Agricultural production:** Most people lived in rural areas and depended directly on land, seasons and local farming. **Example:** A poor harvest could affect the food, rent and survival of an entire village.
- **Local economic organisation:** Production and exchange were often organised around villages, manors and local markets. **Example:** A community might obtain most of its food, tools and services from nearby producers.
- **Strong religious worldview:** Social events were frequently interpreted through divine will, sin, morality and salvation. **Example:** Disease or famine could be understood as a religious trial rather than as a problem of sanitation or agricultural organisation.

A person's position was largely determined by **birth + estate + religion + land**, rather than by individual achievement. Consequently, the social structure appeared almost fixed.

Sociological significance

Sociology emerged when this apparently permanent order began to disintegrate. The discipline is therefore partly the study of the consequences of the transition:

Traditional Society → Modern Society

Example: When a peasant leaves the manor for a factory town, the change is not only economic. It alters occupation, residence, family relations, class identity, religion and the type of social bonds experienced by the person.

Renaissance

Meaning

The **Renaissance**, roughly associated with Europe between the fourteenth and sixteenth centuries, was a revival of art, literature, learning, culture and humanistic thought. It did not instantly destroy medieval society, but it created a new intellectual mood in which human beings, observation and creativity received greater importance.

The Renaissance contributed to:

- **Decline of unquestioned authority:** Religious and political claims were increasingly open to discussion. **Example:** Scholars could debate inherited explanations of nature instead of accepting them only because an authority had stated them.
- **Weakening of feudal structures:** Growing towns, trade and new commercial groups reduced the exclusive control of feudal landowners. **Example:** A wealthy merchant in a city could gain influence without belonging to the old landed nobility.
- **Weakening dominance of theology:** Worldly matters such as art, politics, nature and human anatomy could be studied in their own terms. **Example:** Artists and anatomists examined the human body through observation rather than treating it only as a religious symbol.
- **Independent thinking:** Individuals were encouraged to use their own judgement. **Example:** A scholar might compare texts and evidence instead of repeating the interpretation traditionally taught by an institution.
- **Direct observation of nature:** Knowledge increasingly involved looking at the world carefully. **Example:** The study of plants, stars and the human body became based more on observation and classification.

The Renaissance ultimately helped prepare the ground for the **Scientific Revolution**.

Major contributions

Humanism

Humanism placed human beings, their abilities and their worldly concerns at the centre of intellectual attention. It encouraged the study of language, history, art and human experience.

Example: Instead of discussing only salvation after death, a humanist also studied how education, law and political institutions could improve life in the present world.

Individualism

The individual increasingly came to be viewed as possessing creativity, agency, reason and autonomy. A person was not only a member of an inherited estate but also an active personality capable of achievement.

Example: The recognition of an artist's individual style reflects the growing idea that personal creativity has value.

Questioning authority

Traditional religious and political authorities became open to criticism. Questioning did not automatically mean rejection; it meant that claims had to face discussion and examination.

Example: A thinker could ask whether a king's power should be unlimited or whether political authority required public consent.

Secular orientation

Worldly affairs began to be understood independently of purely theological explanations. Politics, economy and knowledge gradually developed their own institutional spaces.

Example: A city administration could plan roads, markets and public buildings as civic matters rather than treating every decision as a matter for religious authority.

Independent observation

Knowledge increasingly required investigation rather than mere acceptance. This created the intellectual habit that later supported scientific research and social surveys.

Example: A researcher who records disease patterns in a city is using observation to understand a social problem rather than relying only on a traditional belief about its cause.

2024 PYQ - "Sociology is the product of European Enlightenment and Renaissance. Critically examine."

The word "**critically**" requires a balanced answer.

Contribution of Renaissance and Enlightenment

Humanism made human society worthy of study; rationality encouraged explanation through reason; individualism highlighted agency; secularism loosened the exclusive hold of theology; and critical inquiry made inherited institutions open to examination.

Why the statement is incomplete

Sociology was also shaped by the Scientific Revolution, which supplied a method of observation and evidence. The French Revolution created the political problem of order after the collapse of traditional authority. The Industrial Revolution generated capitalism, class conflict, urbanisation and new poverty. Colonialism produced global connections and comparative knowledge. Conservative reactions to revolutionary change made stability and social integration central concerns.

Best judgement

Renaissance and Enlightenment created the intellectual climate of sociology, but sociology emerged from the combined intellectual and structural crisis of European modernity.

Example for an answer: A paragraph on Kant and rationality alone is not enough. It must be connected to the actual social problems created when factories, cities, classes and revolutionary politics transformed European society.

Commercial Revolution

The **Commercial Revolution**, approximately from the fifteenth to the eighteenth centuries, involved a large expansion of trade, markets, maritime commerce, credit, banking and commercial enterprises. It connected distant regions and created economic groups whose power did not depend entirely on feudal land.

Portugal and Spain pioneered important maritime routes. Over time, merchants, bankers and investors became increasingly important in European economic life.

Major groups that gained importance

- **Merchants:** They purchased and sold goods across regions. **Example:** A merchant could bring spices or textiles from an overseas market and sell them in a European city.
- **Bankers:** They provided credit, loans and systems for transferring money. **Example:** A trader could finance a long-distance voyage through borrowed capital rather than depending only on personal savings.
- **Investors:** They put money into ships, trading companies and commercial ventures with the expectation of profit. **Example:** Several investors could share the cost and risk of an overseas trading expedition.

Structural consequences

- **Rise of the middle class:** Economic power was no longer concentrated only among feudal landowners. Merchants and urban professionals acquired wealth and influence. **Example:** A successful city trader could become politically influential even without owning a large rural estate.
- **Expansion of the money economy:** Exchange increasingly depended upon money, credit and contracts rather than only on feudal duties or direct exchange of goods. **Example:** A worker or artisan could be paid in money and use it to buy food and tools from different sellers.
- **Market expansion:** Economic relations became wider and increasingly impersonal. Goods could be produced for unknown buyers in distant places. **Example:** A textile producer in one region might make cloth for customers in another country whom he or she would never meet.
- **Decline of feudal isolation:** Local economies became connected to broader commercial networks. **Example:** The price of a commodity in a local market could be affected by overseas supply and demand.
- **Growth of capitalism:** Commercial capital prepared the ground for industrial capitalism. Profit, investment and accumulation became normal economic goals. **Example:** Capital earned through trade could later be invested in machines, factories and transport.

Commercial Revolution and Colonialism

The expansion of European trade gradually moved beyond commercial exchange towards political domination, territorial control and colonialism. In many places, the relationship changed from **trade towards total control**.

At first, a company or state might seek access to goods and ports. Later, it could control territory, impose taxes, regulate production and use political power to protect its commercial interests.

Example: The East India Company's commercial presence in India gradually developed into political and territorial control. Trade was linked with revenue collection, military power and changes in local production.

Critical point

Modernity cannot be narrated only as:

Reason + Science + Progress

European modernity was also connected with:

- **Colonialism:** Political control over other societies. **Example:** European powers governed territories outside Europe and altered their institutions.
- **Extraction:** Resources, labour and revenue were taken to serve imperial interests. **Example:** Colonial economies were often reorganised to supply raw materials and revenue to the ruling power.
- **Unequal exchange:** The benefits and costs of trade were distributed unequally. **Example:** A colony could export raw material at low value and import finished goods at a higher price.
- **Political domination:** Local societies lost important control over their economy and government. **Example:** Decisions about land revenue or trade could be imposed by a colonial administration.

Modernity therefore contains both **emancipatory possibilities** and **structures of domination**. Scientific knowledge and new rights could challenge old oppression, while the same modern state and economic organisation could be used for conquest and extraction.

Scientific Revolution

The **Scientific Revolution** transformed the method by which knowledge was produced. Instead of depending entirely on tradition, scriptures or inherited authority, greater importance was given to observation, experiment, evidence and rational explanation.

Important fields and developments

- **Astronomy:** The movement of planets and stars was studied through systematic observation. **Example:** The heliocentric view associated with Copernicus placed the Sun, rather than the Earth, at the centre of the planetary system.
- **Physics:** Motion, force and matter were explained through general principles. **Example:** Mechanical laws could be used to explain the movement of objects instead of attributing every event to a separate supernatural cause.
- **Mathematics:** Quantification made comparison and calculation more precise. **Example:** Navigation and engineering benefited from measurement and mathematical calculation.
- **Anatomy:** The human body was studied directly. **Example:** Medical knowledge improved when doctors observed organs and bodily structures rather than relying only on inherited texts.
- **Chemistry:** Substances and their changes were examined experimentally. **Example:** Laboratory methods could test how materials react under different conditions.
- **Navigation:** Scientific knowledge supported long-distance travel and mapping. **Example:** Better maps and instruments assisted maritime trade and European expansion.

Intellectual shift

Earlier pattern:

Authority → Truth

Scientific Revolution:

Evidence → Truth claim

This did not mean that every scientific claim was automatically correct. It meant that a claim could be tested, questioned and revised.

The change encouraged a major sociological question:

If the natural world can be understood through scientific principles, can society also be studied scientifically?

This question later became foundational to **positivism**.

Sociological link

Scientific Revolution → Scientific Temper → Positivism → Auguste Comte → Sociology as a Science

Example: A social researcher who collects data on crime, compares neighbourhoods and looks for regular patterns is applying the broader scientific temper to society.

Critical methodological point

Society cannot simply be treated like physical matter. Human beings possess meaning, intention, consciousness and agency. Two people may respond differently to the same situation because they interpret it differently.

This later produced the debate:

Positivism vs Interpretivism

- Comte and Durkheim emphasised scientific objectivity, observation and social facts. **Example:** A researcher may measure suicide rates and look for social causes.
- Weber emphasised interpretive understanding (**Verstehen**) of social action. **Example:** To understand a religious protest, the researcher must also understand what the protest means to participants.

The scientific method is valuable, but the meaning-making capacity of human beings makes social research more complex than the study of a physical object.

Enlightenment

The **Enlightenment** produced a major intellectual transformation in European thought. It rested on the belief that knowledge based on **reason and experience** was superior to unquestioned religious faith or inherited authority.

It was associated with:

- **Rationalism:** Human reason can examine institutions and beliefs. **Example:** A law may be judged by asking whether it is just and useful, not only whether it is ancient.
- **Secularism:** Social and political questions can be considered through worldly reasoning. **Example:** Government policy can be debated through public welfare and evidence.
- **Humanism:** Human welfare and dignity become central concerns. **Example:** Education and legal reform are justified by their effect on human beings.
- **Republicanism:** Political authority is linked with citizenship and public participation. **Example:** A representative government claims legitimacy from citizens rather than only from hereditary status.
- **Scientific thinking:** Observation, evidence and systematic reasoning are valued. **Example:** A social problem is investigated through facts and surveys.

Enlightenment thinking did not simply remove all traditions. Its major contribution was to make all institutions available for critical examination.

Kant and Enlightenment

In his essay *What is Enlightenment?*, **Immanuel Kant** described Enlightenment as humanity's emergence from self-imposed intellectual immaturity. People remain intellectually immature when they allow others to think for them even though they possess the capacity to reason.

Its spirit can be expressed through:

“Dare to think.”

Reason became connected with:

- **Freedom:** A person must be free to use reason and express an argument. **Example:** Public discussion allows citizens to question government policy.

- **Intellectual autonomy:** Individuals should not depend blindly on an authority for every judgement. **Example:** A student compares evidence before accepting a claim.
- **Critical inquiry:** Existing ideas and institutions can be examined. **Example:** People can ask whether a social hierarchy is just rather than accepting it as natural.

For sociology, Kant's importance lies in the idea that social arrangements are human arrangements and can therefore be examined, criticised and changed.

Sociological Contribution of Enlightenment

Rationalism

Enlightenment rationalism encouraged the belief that institutions could be analysed through reason. Society was no longer treated as an unknowable divine arrangement.

Example: A legal system can be studied by examining how it distributes rights and punishments.

Scientific temper

The belief that systematic observation and evidence can produce knowledge was extended towards society.

Example: A government or researcher can study the causes of school dropout through data on income, gender, distance and social background.

Secularism

Social phenomena did not necessarily require theological explanations. This opened space for economic, political and cultural explanations.

Example: Urban poverty may be linked to wages and housing rather than being explained only through individual sin or fate.

Belief in progress

Societies were considered capable of improvement. This gave legitimacy to reform and planned change.

Example: Abolition of an unjust practice can be defended by arguing that institutions should move towards equality and human dignity.

Individual freedom

Traditional hierarchy became open to criticism. Individuals were increasingly seen as rights-bearing persons.

Example: The idea that a person should have freedom of speech challenges a system in which only a privileged estate can express political views.

Critical examination

Existing institutions could be judged instead of being automatically accepted.

Example: A sociologist may ask whether the education system reproduces class inequality rather than assuming that it is equally beneficial to all.

Human agency

Human beings could actively transform social institutions. Society was not only a fate imposed from outside.

Example: Social movements can demand new laws, labour rights or representation and thereby change institutions.

PYQ hotspot

- **2015:** Contribution of Enlightenment to the emergence of sociology.
- **2022:** Which aspects of Enlightenment paved the way for sociology?
- **2024:** Enlightenment and Renaissance - critically examine.

For the **2022 question**, focus specifically on the features of Enlightenment:

Reason → Science → Secularism → Individualism → Progress → Critique of Tradition → Reform

Do not turn the answer into a general history of the French or Industrial Revolutions. Mention those revolutions only when explaining how Enlightenment ideas entered political and economic life.

Example of a good linkage: Enlightenment reason made people question inherited authority; the French Revolution then converted such questioning into a political challenge to monarchy and privilege.

Political Philosophy as an Intellectual Antecedent

T. B. Bottomore's discussion of the intellectual antecedents of sociology draws attention to political philosophy. Political philosophers questioned authority, rights, the state, freedom, political obligation and the relationship between the individual and society.

Important thinkers

Hobbes

Thomas Hobbes was concerned with political order and authority. He asked how peace could be maintained when individuals have competing interests and when uncontrolled conflict is possible.

Example: A society without a common authority may experience insecurity; this helps explain why people accept a state with power to make and enforce rules.

John Locke

Locke emphasised natural rights such as the right to life, property and personal freedom. Political authority, in this view, should protect rights rather than arbitrarily destroy them.

Example: If a government takes a person's property without legal justification, the idea of natural rights provides a basis for questioning that action.

Voltaire

Voltaire was associated with religious tolerance, freedom of speech and individual rights. His criticism of intolerance encouraged a public sphere in which institutions could be debated.

Example: Allowing people of different faiths to express their beliefs without persecution reflects religious tolerance.

Rousseau

Through the idea of the **Social Contract**, Rousseau emphasised popular sovereignty, legitimate political authority and political participation. Government is legitimate when it represents the general will rather than merely the private interest of a ruler.

Example: The idea that laws should reflect citizens' collective political will is different from the belief that the king's personal command is always law.

Sociological relevance

These thinkers made the state, rights and citizenship central objects of systematic thought. They also created the language through which the French Revolution and modern democracy could be understood.

Philosophy of History

Thinkers such as **Hegel** and **Saint-Simon** strengthened the idea that society and history develop, transform and move through stages. History increasingly came to be understood as a process rather than as a repetitive or permanently static condition.

- **Hegel:** History was understood as a dynamic development shaped by contradictions and changing forms of consciousness. **Example:** A political institution may produce conflicts that lead society to develop a new institution.
- **Saint-Simon:** He highlighted the importance of industrial organisation, science and productive activity in the development of society. **Example:** The rise of industrial and scientific groups could change the structure of authority and economic life.

This historical thinking was important because sociology itself became concerned with the question: Why do societies change?

Example: Instead of treating the family, economy or state as unchanging, sociology compares their older and newer forms and identifies the forces behind the transformation.

Evolutionary Thought

Early evolutionary ideas also influenced sociological thinking. Important influences included **Charles Darwin** and **Herbert Spencer**.

Evolution encouraged interest in:

- **Development:** Social forms can grow and change. **Example:** A small local market may develop into a complex national economy.
- **Differentiation:** Parts of society become more specialised. **Example:** Tasks once performed within the household may be divided among schools, hospitals, offices and factories.
- **Increasing complexity:** Social institutions and relationships can become more numerous and interconnected. **Example:** A modern city depends on transport, finance, education, health and communication systems.

- **Transformation over time:** Social arrangements have histories and do not remain exactly the same. **Example:** Political authority can move from hereditary rule to constitutional government.

Critical point

Biological evolution should not be directly equated with social evolution. Human societies possess culture, consciousness, language and the ability to make choices. Early evolutionary sociology sometimes became:

- **Unilinear:** It assumed that all societies pass through one fixed sequence. **Example:** It placed every society on a single ladder leading towards European industrial society.
- **Deterministic:** It treated change as automatic and inevitable. **Example:** It ignored the role of human struggle, political choices and historical accidents.
- **Eurocentric:** It treated European society as the highest stage. **Example:** Non-European institutions were judged as backward rather than studied in their own historical context.

Modern sociology rejects the assumption that every society must travel along one identical path:

Traditional → European-style modernity

Example: India may combine democratic institutions, digital technology and capitalism with caste, kinship and religious traditions. This is not simply an incomplete copy of Europe; it is a distinct modern configuration.

Reform Movements and Social Surveys

Reform movements encouraged people to view poverty, crime, poor housing and labour problems not merely as individual misfortune but as **social problems**. Once a problem is understood as social, it becomes possible to investigate its causes and design collective solutions.

- **Poverty:** Instead of blaming only the poor, reformers examined wages, unemployment, housing and access to education. **Example:** If many workers remain poor despite working long hours, the wage system and labour conditions must be studied.
- **Crime:** Crime began to be examined in relation to neighbourhoods, family conditions, education and social exclusion. **Example:** A high crime rate in a crowded settlement may be linked to unemployment and weak public services, not only to the character of individuals.
- **Poor housing:** Reformers connected disease and suffering with overcrowding and sanitation. **Example:** A survey may show that tuberculosis is common where many families share small, poorly ventilated rooms.

- **Labour problems:** Long hours, unsafe workplaces and low wages became matters of public debate. **Example:** Factory accidents can lead to demands for safety rules and inspection.

The **social survey** developed from the belief that systematic empirical investigation could also be used to study human society. It involved collecting information about households, work, income, health, housing and social conditions.

Example: poverty as a changing idea

Earlier understanding:

Poverty = Natural or individual condition

Later sociological understanding:

Poverty = Socially produced condition requiring investigation

If many people in one industrial city live in poverty, sociology asks whether low wages, unequal property distribution, migration, labour relations or public policy are producing the pattern.

Sociological importance

This represents the shift:

Moral judgement → Social explanation

Instead of asking, “Why are poor individuals unsuccessful?”, sociology asks, “Which social structures produce or reproduce poverty?”

Example: A school dropout is not explained only by laziness. A sociologist may examine household income, gender norms, distance from school, child labour, discrimination and the quality of teaching.

French Revolution

The **French Revolution of 1789** was one of the defining political events of European modernity. French society was divided into three broad estates. The **Third Estate represented the overwhelming majority of the population**, but political privileges were concentrated in the First and Second Estates.

Political inequality, economic difficulties, state financial crisis and Enlightenment criticism contributed to revolutionary upheaval.

The Revolution challenged:

- **Absolute monarchy:** The king's power was no longer treated as unlimited. **Example:** Political decisions came to be judged in relation to the rights and will of citizens.
- **Feudal privilege:** Hereditary privileges and special dues were attacked. **Example:** The legal advantages of a privileged estate could be questioned by people who carried most of the tax burden.
- **Traditional political legitimacy:** Authority based only on birth and divine right lost credibility. **Example:** A ruler had to justify power through a new language of citizenship and popular sovereignty.

The Revolution strengthened ideas of:

- **Liberty:** Individuals should have freedom from arbitrary authority. **Example:** A citizen should not be imprisoned simply because a ruler dislikes him or her.
- **Equality:** Legal and political privilege based on birth was challenged. **Example:** The law should not give different rights merely because a person belongs to a noble estate.
- **Citizenship:** People became members of a political community with rights and duties. **Example:** A citizen is not only a subject who obeys but also a participant in public life.
- **Popular sovereignty:** Political authority ultimately belongs to the people. **Example:** Government is considered legitimate when it derives from the collective will of citizens.

The new mind map describes the French Revolution as a watershed event that reshaped the modern world.

Intellectual Background of the French Revolution

Thinkers such as **Montesquieu, Voltaire and Rousseau** supplied ideas that encouraged criticism of established institutions.

- **Montesquieu:** His discussion of separation of powers encouraged the idea that political authority should not be concentrated in one hand. **Example:** An independent judiciary can check the misuse of power by the executive.
- **Voltaire:** His criticism of religious intolerance and arbitrary authority supported freedom of speech and rational public debate. **Example:** A person should be able to question a religious or political institution without facing arbitrary punishment.
- **Rousseau:** His ideas of the social contract, popular sovereignty and the general will questioned monarchical power and hereditary privilege. **Example:** A law gains legitimacy when citizens participate in its political foundation rather than receiving it as the private command of a king.

Their thinking encouraged people to question monarchical power, religious domination, hereditary privilege and political inequality.

Sociological Significance of the French Revolution

Inequality and power

The Revolution raised the question: How can a deeply unequal society remain stable? The answer cannot be found only in the formal existence of a government; it also requires examining who receives privilege and who bears burdens.

Example: If a small group enjoys political exemption while the majority pays taxes, resentment can create a crisis of legitimacy.

Religion and politics

Political authority increasingly became detached from religious authority. This contributed to secular political institutions and a new relationship between citizens and the state.

Example: A government may frame laws through a constitution and public debate even when citizens follow different religions.

Progress

The Revolution showed that human beings could consciously reconstruct institutions. Society was not permanently fixed by tradition.

Example: A constitution can be written to replace a hereditary political order.

Social change

Society was no longer understood as a naturally permanent hierarchy. Revolution made rapid, disruptive transformation visible.

Example: A social estate that existed for centuries can lose its legal privileges in a short period when political conditions change.

Social order

Once traditional authority collapses, what holds society together? New rights and political institutions may create freedom, but they must also produce rules, trust and cooperation.

Example: After the fall of a monarchy, a society needs laws, administration and common citizenship to prevent permanent conflict.

Durkheim and the French Revolution

The French Revolution can be connected with **Émile Durkheim's** interest in collective life. Revolutionary events bring people together through common symbols, shared emotion and collective action.

The concept of **collective effervescence** helps explain moments when individuals experience intense collective unity and shared emotion. In such moments, a crowd feels that it is part of something larger than each individual.

Example: Large public gatherings, revolutionary ceremonies, national celebrations or mass movements can create a strong feeling of solidarity. People sing the same song, carry the same symbols and experience a temporary emotional unity.

The sociological lesson is that political order is not maintained only by laws or force. Shared beliefs, symbols and collective emotions can also bind people together.

Marx and the French Revolution

Karl Marx offered a more critical interpretation of the political changes associated with modernity. He argued that political emancipation alone did not necessarily create complete human emancipation.

The Revolution could produce formal legal equality while economic inequality and class domination continued.

- **Formal equality:** Citizens may be declared equal before the law. **Example:** The law may recognise everyone as having the same civil status.
- **Economic inequality:** People may still own very different amounts of property and income. **Example:** A wealthy property owner and a landless worker may have equal legal status but very unequal life chances.

- **Property inequality:** Control over productive resources gives some groups greater power. **Example:** The owner of factories can influence production decisions while workers depend on wages.
- **Class domination:** Economic control can shape political and social relationships. **Example:** A worker may be legally free to leave a job but have no realistic alternative because survival depends on wages.

High-value critical line

The French Revolution created:

Political equality without necessarily producing economic equality.

This distinction later became central to Marxist sociology.

The Central Problem Created by the French Revolution

The Revolution produced two opposite effects at the same time.

Emancipation

- **Citizenship:** People were recognised as members of a political community. **Example:** The common citizen became a political subject rather than only a subordinate of a king.
- **Rights:** Individuals received a language for claiming liberty and equality. **Example:** A citizen could demand protection from arbitrary punishment.
- **Equality:** Hereditary legal privilege was challenged. **Example:** The law could no longer openly reserve every important office for one estate.
- **Political participation:** The people became a source of political legitimacy. **Example:** Representative institutions and public opinion gained importance.

Disorder

- **Breakdown of established authority:** Old institutions lost obedience. **Example:** A king's order might no longer be accepted as automatically legitimate.
- **Conflict:** Different groups struggled over power and the direction of change. **Example:** Popular groups, property owners and political factions could demand different outcomes.
- **Institutional instability:** New arrangements were not immediately settled. **Example:** A society may pass through several constitutional forms before finding stability.

- **Uncertainty:** Individuals may not know which rules, status and institutions will survive. **Example:** Property, office and public identity can become insecure during revolutionary transition.

Therefore sociology inherited one major question:

How is social order possible in a rapidly changing society?

This question became particularly important for **Comte** and **Durkheim**, who tried to explain how modern society could achieve stability without simply returning to the old feudal order.

Industrial Revolution

The **Industrial Revolution** began in Britain around the second half of the eighteenth century. It was a long process in which production moved from small household and craft settings to factories using machines, new sources of energy and large-scale organisation.

It involved a transition from:

- **Agrarian production → Industrial production:** The main source of employment and wealth shifted towards manufacturing and industry. **Example:** A village economy based mainly on farming could become a town centred on textile mills.
- **Household production → Factory production:** Goods that were earlier made at home or in small workshops were increasingly produced at a central workplace. **Example:** Spinning that was once done by family members at home became work performed by many labourers inside a mill.
- **Manual production → Mechanisation:** Machines increased the speed and scale of production. **Example:** A machine could produce cloth faster than an individual handloom worker, although it also changed the worker's skill and control over the work.
- **Feudal economy → Capitalist economy:** Production became organised around private ownership, investment, wage labour and profit. **Example:** A factory owner purchased machines and hired workers instead of depending upon feudal obligations tied to land.
- **Wood-based energy → Increasing use of coal:** Coal and steam power supported machinery, transport and factories. **Example:** Coal-fired steam engines could operate factory machinery and move goods by rail.
- **Small-scale production → Mass production:** Goods were produced in larger quantities for wider markets. **Example:** Standardised products could be made for thousands of consumers rather than one local customer at a time.

Industrialisation was therefore not only a technological change. It reorganised class relations, cities, family life, time discipline, work and the relationship between the individual and the community.

Four Broad Phases of Industrial Transformation

The industrial transformation can be understood as a long sequence rather than a process that ended after the first factories.

First phase - Late eighteenth century

This phase was marked by mechanisation, water power and steam power. Machines began to replace or reorganise manual processes.

Example: A textile mill using water or steam power could bring many workers and machines together at one site.

Second phase - Early twentieth century

Electricity, mass production and specialised production became important. Production lines and division of labour made it possible to produce standard goods rapidly.

Example: In an automobile factory, one worker may fit a particular component while another performs a different task on the same production line.

Third phase - From around the 1970s

Automation, electronics, information technology and programmable machinery transformed production. Machines could perform repetitive tasks with limited direct human intervention.

Example: A computer-controlled machine can cut, assemble or inspect a product with consistent accuracy.

Contemporary phase

Digitisation, advanced electronics, information technology and networked production connect factories, suppliers and consumers across countries.

Example: A product may be designed in one country, use components from several other countries, be assembled elsewhere and be sold through an online platform worldwide.

Contemporary extension

The process continues through:

Artificial Intelligence + Automation + Platform Economy + Algorithms + Robotics

Thus, industrial modernity has not ended; its technological form has changed.

Example: A delivery worker may receive tasks, directions and performance ratings through an algorithm rather than from a human supervisor standing in a factory.

Industrial Revolution - Economic Changes

Industrialisation produced:

- **Capitalism:** Production was increasingly directed towards investment and profit. **Example:** Profit from one production cycle could be reinvested in larger machines or a new factory.
- **Factory production:** Workers, machines and raw materials were brought together under one organisation. **Example:** A textile factory coordinated spinning, weaving and finishing in a common workplace.
- **Expansion of markets:** Factories required large numbers of buyers and sources of raw material. **Example:** Railways allowed factory goods to reach distant markets quickly.
- **Private property:** Productive resources such as factories, machines and mines were increasingly owned privately. **Example:** A capitalist owner could decide how a factory was used and how its profits were distributed.
- **Division of labour:** Work was divided into specialised tasks. **Example:** In a production line, each worker performs only one part of the total process.
- **Wage labour:** Workers received wages in exchange for their labour power. **Example:** A worker who does not own a factory survives by finding employment and selling the capacity to work.
- **Large-scale organisations:** Production required managers, administrators, engineers, accountants and systems of supervision. **Example:** A large company has different departments for production, finance, human resources and marketing.

Production increasingly separated into two broad positions:

Owners

Owners control capital, factories and productive resources. They take decisions about investment, production and the use of technology.

Example: The owner of a mill decides what to produce, how many machines to install and how many workers to employ.

Workers

Workers possess primarily their **labour power**. They generally do not own the factory or the main productive resources and therefore depend upon employment for income.

Example: A worker may be highly skilled in operating a machine but still have no control over the factory's profits or overall production decisions.

This economic separation became the basis for Marx's analysis of class conflict.

Emergence of New Class Structure

Industrial society generated new class formations that were different from the old feudal estates.

Bourgeoisie / Capitalist class

The bourgeoisie owned capital and productive resources such as factories, machines, mines and commercial enterprises. Their social power came from ownership and control over production.

Example: A factory owner can employ workers, decide the production process and receive the surplus generated by the sale of goods.

Proletariat / Working class

The proletariat consisted of wage labourers who depended upon employment. They did not generally own the means of production and had to sell their labour power to survive.

Example: A mill worker earns a wage by working a fixed number of hours but does not own the machinery or the finished products.

Middle classes

Industrial society also expanded managers, professionals, administrators, clerical workers and traders. They occupied positions between the major owners and manual workers, although the exact class location of each group could vary.

Examples:

- A **manager** supervises workers and production on behalf of an organisation.
- A **professional** uses specialised knowledge, such as a doctor, lawyer or engineer.
- An **administrator** implements rules and coordinates public or private institutions.
- A **clerical worker** performs office and record-keeping work.
- A **trader** buys and sells goods in the market.

Industrialisation was also connected with growing social mobility and the restructuring of the European class order. However, new classes did not mean the disappearance of inequality. Inequality was reorganised around ownership, income, skill and employment.

The Discovery of “Social Poverty”

The updated material makes an important distinction between natural poverty and social poverty.

Natural poverty

Poverty was understood as an inevitable or natural condition, or as the result of an individual's weakness, laziness or fate.

Example: If a worker remains poor, society may simply say that the person was unlucky or did not work hard enough.

Social poverty

Poverty was understood as emerging from particular social and economic arrangements. Industrial capitalism encouraged thinkers to ask how wages, property relations and labour institutions produced poverty.

It could result from:

- **Labour relations:** The relationship between employer and worker may keep wages low. **Example:** A worker may work for long hours but receive too little income to afford decent housing.
- **Low wages:** Employment does not always remove poverty if wages remain below the cost of living. **Example:** A full-time worker may still be unable to provide food, rent and education for the family.
- **Class inequality:** Different classes have unequal access to property, power and security. **Example:** The owner can accumulate profit while the worker faces unemployment when the factory closes.

- **Property distribution:** Ownership of land, factories and financial resources is concentrated.
Example: A person without productive property must depend on wages while an owner receives income from property.
- **Economic organisation:** The wider market and production system can create insecurity and unemployment. **Example:** A fall in demand may close a factory even when workers are willing to work.

UPSC value addition

Industrial society transformed poverty from a “natural condition” into a **social question**. This is important because a social question demands research, public debate, reform and institutional action.

Example: A social survey of an industrial neighbourhood may reveal that poverty is connected with low wages, overcrowding and lack of sanitation. This can lead to labour laws and housing reform rather than only charity.

Urbanisation

Factories attracted large populations towards emerging industrial cities. This movement changed not only the size of cities but also the nature of social relationships.

- **Rural-urban migration:** People moved from villages to cities in search of employment. **Example:** A young person leaves an agricultural village to work in a textile or construction industry in a city.
- **Rapid urban growth:** Cities expanded faster than housing, transport and public services. **Example:** New settlements may appear around factories before roads, schools and hospitals are available.
- **Overcrowding:** Many people lived close together, often in small and poorly ventilated rooms. **Example:** Several families may share a building near a factory because rent is high.
- **New occupations:** Industry created factory work, clerical work, transport, trade and technical employment. **Example:** A railway expansion creates jobs for mechanics, ticket clerks, drivers and warehouse workers.
- **Weakening of traditional community bonds:** In a village, people may know each other through kinship and long-term interaction. In a city, relationships may become more temporary and specialised. **Example:** A worker can live among hundreds of neighbours without knowing their family background.
- **Impersonal social relations:** Market and bureaucratic relations often operate through contracts, money and formal rules. **Example:** A person buys a service from an unknown provider rather than receiving it through a customary community obligation.

- **New forms of poverty:** Urban poverty developed through unemployment, low wages, high rent and insecure work. **Example:** A worker may have employment but live in a slum because city housing is unaffordable.
- **Social disorganisation:** Rapid change may weaken old norms before new forms of cooperation become stable. **Example:** A migrant settlement may lack trusted institutions for resolving disputes or helping vulnerable people.

Urbanisation therefore became one of the central subjects of sociology. It made visible the changes in class, family, crime, community and social control.

Reorganisation of Labour

Earlier production was often connected to family, household, craft and community. A craftsperson could have some control over tools, pace and the finished product.

Industrial capitalism increasingly separated:

Home from workplace

and

Worker from control over production

Meaning of the change

- Work was performed at a fixed factory or office rather than inside the home. **Example:** A weaver who once worked with family members at home now reports to a factory at a fixed time.
- Time became disciplined by the clock and by the employer. **Example:** The worker must arrive at 8 a.m., follow a shift and meet a production target.
- Ownership of tools and raw material moved to the capitalist organisation. **Example:** The worker operates a machine but does not own it.
- The worker may complete only one small task and may not see the final product. **Example:** One person attaches a component without knowing how the entire product is designed or sold.

This reorganisation increased productivity but also produced dependence, supervision and the possibility of alienation.

Marx: Industrial Revolution and Alienation

For **Karl Marx**, capitalist industrialisation transformed social relationships fundamentally. Workers became increasingly separated from four important aspects of work and human life.

Alienation from the product

The product belongs to the capitalist or organisation, not to the worker who produced it.

Example: A worker assembles a phone but cannot use, own or decide the price of the phone as the creator of the product.

Alienation from the production process

The worker has little control over how work is organised, at what speed it is performed or what tools are used.

Example: An employee repeats the same task according to a machine schedule and cannot change the process even if it feels meaningless or unsafe.

Alienation from fellow workers

Workers may compete with one another for jobs, wages, promotion or ratings instead of cooperating as a community.

Example: If workers compete for a limited number of shifts, each may see the other as a rival rather than as a collective group with common interests.

Alienation from human potential

Creative, social and self-developing abilities are reduced when work becomes repetitive and controlled by others.

Example: A person capable of creative problem-solving may spend the entire shift performing one repetitive action with no opportunity to make decisions.

The updated mind map connects the Industrial Revolution with alienation and the distancing of individuals under capitalist production.

Critical dimension of modern capitalism

Industrial capitalism produced contradictory outcomes:

- **Productivity + exploitation:** Machines and factories produced more goods, but workers could be paid poorly or made to work under unsafe conditions. **Example:** A factory may produce large output while labourers work long hours without adequate protection.
- **Wealth + poverty:** Total wealth increased, but it was distributed unequally. **Example:** A prosperous industrial district may exist next to a crowded workers' settlement.
- **Freedom of contract + economic dependence:** Workers were legally free to sign or leave a contract, but poverty might leave them with very few real choices. **Example:** A worker accepts dangerous work because refusing it may mean hunger or homelessness.
- **Mobility + insecurity:** People could move to cities and change occupations, but employment could also be temporary and unstable. **Example:** A migrant may find a job quickly but lose it when demand falls.

This contradictory character of modernity is central to Marx.

Durkheim: Division of Labour

For **Émile Durkheim**, industrialisation increased occupational specialisation, functional differentiation and interdependence. People performed different tasks, but each depended on the work of others.

Mechanical solidarity

Mechanical solidarity is based on similarity. People share similar work, beliefs, lifestyles and collective traditions. The collective conscience is strong and individual differences are limited.

Example: In a small village where most families farm, follow common customs and participate in common rituals, social unity is largely based on likeness.

Organic solidarity

Organic solidarity is based on differentiation and interdependence. People perform different occupations, but their specialised roles connect them.

Example: In a modern city, a doctor, farmer, driver, teacher, engineer and sanitation worker perform different tasks, yet each depends on the services of others.

Society therefore moves increasingly from:

Mechanical Solidarity → Organic Solidarity

Critical add-on: anomie

Division of labour does not automatically produce healthy solidarity. Rapid transformation may generate **anomie**, a condition in which norms are weak, unclear or unable to regulate new relationships.

Example: A migrant entering a rapidly changing city may lose the clear rules of the old community but may not yet feel integrated into the new urban order. Similarly, a worker may face unlimited competition and uncertain expectations without a shared moral framework.

Durkheim's contribution is therefore balanced: specialisation can create interdependence, but society must also provide moral regulation.

Weber: Industrialisation and Rationalisation

For **Max Weber**, modernity was characterised by increasing **rationalisation**. Modern institutions increasingly operate through calculation, rules, efficiency, predictability and formal organisation.

- **Calculation:** Decisions are made by measuring costs, time, output and benefit. **Example:** A company calculates the number of workers and machines required to meet a production target.
- **Rules:** Behaviour is regulated through written procedures. **Example:** A government office processes an application according to fixed eligibility rules.
- **Efficiency:** Institutions seek the greatest output with the least waste. **Example:** A production line is reorganised to reduce time between two tasks.
- **Predictability:** Regular procedures make behaviour and outcomes easier to anticipate. **Example:** A citizen expects a passport application to follow a known process and time frame.
- **Formal organisation:** Large institutions divide responsibilities among offices and officials. **Example:** A university has departments, registrars, examination cells and financial offices.

Rationalisation is especially visible in capitalism, bureaucracy, law and administration.

Example: A bank approves a loan through forms, credit records, risk calculations and standard rules rather than through a personal relationship alone.

Critical point

Rationalisation increases efficiency, but may also reduce autonomy. Weber's argument helps us understand the tension:

Greater rational organisation ↔ Greater bureaucratic control

Example: A hospital may treat patients more efficiently through digital records and protocols, but staff may feel that their judgement is restricted by rigid targets and forms.

Parsons: Industrialisation and Family

The updated material links **Talcott Parsons** with the transformation of family under industrial society. Industrialisation changed the structure of family, the roles of family members and the relationship between the family and other institutions.

Parsons argued that the modern industrial society is compatible with a relatively small and mobile family because many functions once performed by the extended family are taken over by specialised institutions.

Example: A school performs formal education, a hospital provides specialised health care, and a workplace provides employment. The family continues to provide emotional support and early socialisation but is no longer the sole centre of every activity.

This argument should be used carefully. It helps explain structural change, but it should not be used to claim that every society follows one identical family pattern.

Industrialisation and Family Transformation

Industrial society changed family life through several connected mechanisms.

Production

Household production → Factory production

Earlier, family members could produce goods within or near the household. Factory production took work outside the home and made the wage relationship more important.

Example: A family that earlier spun yarn at home may now depend on one or more members earning wages in a mill.

Residence

Local family economy → Urban migration

Factories were concentrated in towns and cities. Families or young members migrated to find work, weakening the old connection between residence, land and kinship.

Example: A rural household may send a son or daughter to an industrial city, creating a long-distance relationship with the village family.

Occupation

Hereditary occupation → Occupational differentiation

Industrial society required new technical, administrative and professional roles. Occupation became less directly tied to family lineage.

Example: A child of a farmer could become an engineer, clerk or factory manager through education and training.

Functions

The family lost some economic and educational functions to specialised institutions.

Example: Children may receive formal education in school instead of learning all occupational skills within the family workshop.

Mobility

Geographical and social mobility increased. People could move for employment and could sometimes improve their status through education or occupation.

Example: A worker moves from a village to a city and later becomes a supervisor after acquiring technical skills.

Structure

Industrial society was considered more compatible with relatively smaller and mobile family units because such families could move easily with employment.

Example: A small household may shift to another city when a job opportunity arises, whereas a very large kin group may find such movement more difficult.

Direct PYQ - 2014

“How did the emergence of industrial society change family life in Western Europe?”

Do not write merely that the joint family became nuclear. Show the mechanism:

Industrialisation → Occupational mobility → Urbanisation → Separation of workplace/home → Role differentiation → Changing family functions

Add Parsons for theoretical value, and mention that the pattern was not identical for every class or society.

Example of a complete linkage: A factory attracts rural workers to the city; work moves away from the household; children attend specialised schools; family members take separate occupations; family relationships and responsibilities are reorganised.

Rise of Social Mobility

Modern society weakened the absolute control of birth over social position. Education, occupation, income, skill and achievement became more important sources of status.

- **Education:** Formal qualifications can open new occupations. **Example:** A person from a low-income family can qualify for a professional job through schooling and higher education.
- **Occupation:** Industrial society creates many specialised jobs. **Example:** A person can move from a manual job to a supervisory position after acquiring technical training.
- **Income:** Earning and accumulation can change a person's material position. **Example:** A small trader may become economically prosperous through successful business.
- **Skill:** Technical and professional skills are rewarded in modern organisations. **Example:** A trained programmer may find employment in a sector unrelated to the occupation of the family.
- **Achievement:** Personal performance is formally valued more than hereditary rank. **Example:** Competitive examinations select candidates on the basis of performance rather than estate alone.

However, mobility did not eliminate inequality. Access to mobility continues to depend on class, gender, education, cultural capital and social networks.

Critical point

Open society does not mean equal society.

Example: Two students may appear equally free to apply for a competitive examination, but one may have better schooling, coaching, digital access, nutrition and family support. Formal opportunity exists, but actual chances remain unequal.

Transformation of Property

Under feudalism, **land** was the major source of economic and political power. Industrial capitalism increased the importance of capital, factory ownership, investment and financial resources.

- **Capital:** Money and financial resources could be invested to generate more wealth. **Example:** A capitalist uses savings or credit to purchase machines and expand production.
- **Factory ownership:** Control over the workplace became a source of power. **Example:** The owner decides production, employment and the distribution of profits.
- **Investment:** Future production depended upon putting resources into technology, transport and enterprise. **Example:** Investors finance a railway or factory expecting future returns.
- **Financial resources:** Banks, credit and financial institutions influenced economic activity. **Example:** A business with access to credit can expand more quickly than a similar business without loans.

Economic power therefore shifted increasingly towards capitalist property. This change is central to Marx's analysis of class because ownership of productive property determines power in the production process.

Transformation of Occupational Roles

Modern industry required specialisation, technical skills and professional differentiation. Occupation became increasingly detached from hereditary caste- or estate-like location in European society.

- **Specialisation:** A worker performs a specific task. **Example:** One employee maintains machines while another checks product quality.

- **Technical skills:** Modern production requires knowledge of machinery, engineering and information systems. **Example:** A person trained in electrical maintenance can work in several industrial settings.
- **Professional differentiation:** New occupations develop with specialised education and codes of conduct. **Example:** Doctors, engineers, teachers and accountants perform roles that did not exist in their present form in a feudal village.

This contributed to a broader **division of labour**, in which people became different in their work but connected through mutual dependence.

Problems Generated by Industrial Society

Industrialisation generated both growth and serious social problems.

- **Poverty:** Low and irregular wages could leave working families unable to meet basic needs. **Example:** A worker may be employed but still unable to afford safe housing.
- **Exploitation:** Employers could extract long hours and high output from workers who had weak bargaining power. **Example:** A factory owner may extend shifts without a proportionate increase in wages.
- **Unsafe working conditions:** Machines, mines and factories could cause injury or death. **Example:** A worker may be injured because safety guards are absent from a machine.
- **Long working hours:** The factory clock and demand for profit often produced exhausting shifts. **Example:** Workers may spend most of the day inside the factory and have little time for family life.
- **Urban slums:** Rapid migration produced overcrowded settlements with poor sanitation. **Example:** New workers live in narrow rooms near the factory because formal housing is too expensive.
- **Alienation:** Workers lose control over the product, process, fellow workers and creative potential. **Example:** Repetitive work can make a person feel separated from the meaning of the activity.
- **Class inequality:** Owners and workers occupy unequal positions in production and income. **Example:** The factory owner accumulates profits while workers remain dependent upon wages.
- **Labour conflict:** Workers organise and protest over wages, safety and dignity. **Example:** A strike may demand shorter hours and recognition of a workers' association.
- **Social disorganisation:** Rapid change weakens older rules and relationships. **Example:** Migrants may face isolation and lack common institutions for resolving problems.

The original notes therefore connect industrial transformation with worker exploitation and the rise of new bourgeois and capitalist classes.

Why These Problems Produced Sociology

Traditional institutions were weakening, but new institutions did not automatically produce harmony. The new social conditions forced thinkers to ask questions that were specifically sociological.

- **Why is inequality increasing? Example:** Why do factories create large profits for owners while workers remain poor?
- **What holds modern society together? Example:** If people no longer share one village, religion or inherited status, what produces cooperation?
- **Why does conflict occur? Example:** Why do employers and workers repeatedly disagree over wages and working time?
- **What happens when community weakens? Example:** What happens to social support when a migrant family moves to an anonymous city?
- **How is social order possible? Example:** How can millions of strangers follow common rules in a modern nation-state?
- **Why does modernity produce alienation? Example:** Why can a worker feel powerless even when industrial production has increased wealth?
- **What determines social change? Example:** Is change driven mainly by technology, class conflict, ideas, political institutions or a combination of these?

This is the real sociological background to the discipline: sociology emerged as a systematic attempt to understand new social structures and their consequences.

The Two Master Problems of Classical Sociology

A. Problem of order

Main question: What holds modern society together?

This problem was associated particularly with **Comte** and **Durkheim**. The old sources of authority were weakening, so sociology had to identify the new bases of regulation, solidarity and integration.

Example: In a diverse city, common law, institutions, professional interdependence and shared civic values may help people cooperate even when they do not share the same family or religion.

B. Problem of change and conflict

Main question: Why does society change and why does conflict arise?

This problem was associated particularly with **Marx**. Modern society was shaped by new property relations, class interests and struggles over the distribution of wealth and power.

Example: Workers organise because their interests in wages and security may conflict with an owner's interest in reducing costs and increasing profit.

Weber's additional question

What makes modern society increasingly rationalised?

Weber examined the spread of calculation, formal rules, bureaucracy and predictable administration.

The central mapping is:

- **Comte → Order:** Sociology should help understand and reorganise society scientifically. **Example:** A scientific study of social conditions may guide reforms that restore stability.
- **Marx → Capitalism and conflict:** Class relations and ownership produce inequality and struggle. **Example:** The conflict between capital and labour explains strikes and exploitation.
- **Durkheim → Solidarity:** Division of labour can create interdependence, but lack of regulation can cause anomie. **Example:** Specialised occupations connect people, while weak norms create insecurity.
- **Weber → Rationalisation:** Modern institutions become rule-bound, calculative and bureaucratic. **Example:** A government office functions through written files, qualifications and fixed procedures.

Auguste Comte

Auguste Comte is regarded as one of the founding figures of sociology. He wanted to apply scientific principles to the study of society.

His concern arose from the crisis created by the transition:

Traditional Society → Modern Society

The French Revolution had challenged the old political order, while industrialisation and urbanisation were changing economic and social life. Comte believed that society needed scientific knowledge to understand change and restore order.

The updated mind map summarises his contribution as follows:

Sociology became necessary because the transition to modern society produced an intellectual and social crisis.

Example: If old religious and political rules no longer regulate behaviour but new institutions are not yet trusted, a scientific study of social relationships may help identify the sources of disorder and possible bases of cooperation.

Social Statics and Social Dynamics

Comte divided sociology into two connected parts.

Social statics

Social statics studies social order, stability and the interdependence of institutions. It asks how family, religion, economy, government and other institutions fit together at a particular time.

Example: To understand social stability, a sociologist studies how education prepares people for occupations, how law controls conflict and how family provides socialisation.

Social dynamics

Social dynamics studies change, development and social evolution. It asks how societies move from one condition to another and what forces produce that movement.

Example: A researcher studies how the shift from village agriculture to factory employment changed class relations and family residence.

Remember

Statics = How society remains together

Dynamics = How society changes

Both are necessary. Studying only stability misses transformation, while studying only change misses the institutions that maintain continuity.

Comte's Law of Three Stages

According to Comte, human thought develops through three stages. This was his evolutionary account of the movement of knowledge.

Theological stage

Events are explained through supernatural powers, gods or divine will.

Example: A drought may be explained primarily as the result of divine displeasure or supernatural action.

Metaphysical stage

Events are explained through abstract concepts or forces rather than through specific supernatural beings.

Example: A political event may be explained through an abstract “natural force” or “essence” without systematic empirical investigation.

Positive stage

Explanation is based on observation, scientific reasoning, evidence and the search for regularities.

Example: A drought is studied through rainfall data, climate patterns, soil conditions and water management.

The positive stage made sociology possible as a science because social phenomena could be studied for patterns, relationships and causes.

Criticism

Comte's model is criticised for being:

- **Unilinear:** It presents one fixed sequence for all societies. **Example:** It assumes every society must pass through the same intellectual path.
- **Deterministic:** It gives the impression that change follows an automatic law. **Example:** It underestimates political struggle and human choice.
- **Evolutionary in a narrow sense:** It ranks stages as if later automatically means superior. **Example:** It may treat scientific knowledge as replacing all other forms of meaning.

- **Eurocentric:** It often uses European history as the implied universal standard. **Example:** Different historical experiences of Asian or African societies are not adequately recognised.

Religious, metaphysical and scientific orientations can coexist within the same modern society. **Example:** A person may use modern medicine while also holding religious beliefs about suffering and recovery.

Herbert Spencer

Herbert Spencer used an **organic analogy**. He compared society with an organism whose parts are differentiated, interdependent and functionally connected.

Institutions such as family, economy, religion and politics perform different but related roles.

- **Family:** Socialises children and provides emotional and domestic support. **Example:** A family teaches language, habits and basic values.
- **Economy:** Produces and distributes goods and services. **Example:** Firms organise production and employment.
- **Religion:** Provides meanings, moral ideas and collective symbols. **Example:** Religious rituals may bring people together and guide conduct.
- **Politics:** Makes collective decisions and maintains order. **Example:** Government creates laws and public institutions.

In an organism, a change in one part may affect other parts. Similarly, a change in the economy can influence family, education and politics.

Example: Industrialisation changes the workplace; this affects residence, family roles, education and political demands.

Criticism

Society is not literally a biological organism. Human beings possess consciousness, reflexivity, agency and the capacity for resistance.

Example: A worker does not merely perform a functional role like an organ; workers can question rules, organise collectively and demand change.

Spencer's evolutionary model also risks treating European modernity as the universal endpoint.

Example: It may wrongly suggest that every society must copy the same institutional path to become modern.

Intellectual Forces Behind Sociology - Bottomore Framework

The updated notes provide a useful framework for the 2020 Intellectual Forces PYQ. Sociology emerged through the interaction of several intellectual developments rather than from one single event.

Political philosophy

It supplied ideas about rights, the state, individual freedom and political obligation.

Example: Locke's natural rights and Rousseau's social contract encouraged people to ask why governments exist and when authority is legitimate.

Philosophy of history

It treated history as a process of development and transformation.

Example: Hegel and Saint-Simon encouraged the study of the forces through which societies move from one institutional form to another.

Evolutionary thought

It directed attention towards development, differentiation and increasing complexity.

Example: Spencer's comparison of social differentiation helped early sociologists think about the changing functions of institutions.

Social reform movements

They turned poverty, crime, poor housing and labour problems into matters of public concern.

Example: Reformers investigated urban living conditions and demanded changes in sanitation, housing and labour laws.

Social survey / empirical investigation

It demonstrated that systematic data could be collected about human society.

Example: A household survey can record income, occupation, housing, health and education to identify patterns of poverty.

2020 PYQ demand

“How did the intellectual forces lead to the emergence of Sociology?”

Do not make the Industrial Revolution the entire answer. The answer should show the following chain:

Political Philosophy

→ rights, state and individual

Enlightenment

→ rationalism and secularism

Philosophy of History

→ systematic understanding of social change

Evolutionary Thinking

→ development and differentiation

Scientific Revolution

→ scientific method

Social Survey

→ empirical investigation

Positivism

→ sociology as science

Industrialisation should be mentioned as the social context in which these ideas became urgently necessary. **Example:** Scientific method existed as an intellectual resource, but urban poverty and class conflict gave it a concrete social problem to investigate.

A Comprehensive Model: Factors Responsible for the Emergence of Sociology

Sociology emerged through the interaction of four broad transformations. These transformations should be connected in an answer rather than written as unrelated historical facts.

Intellectual transformation

- **Renaissance:** Humanism, individualism and questioning of authority. **Example:** Human experience and observation became legitimate subjects of study.
- **Enlightenment:** Rationalism, secularism, critical inquiry and belief in progress. **Example:** Institutions could be judged by reason rather than by age or religious authority.
- **Scientific Revolution:** Observation, experiment and evidence. **Example:** The habit of testing claims later influenced positivist sociology.
- **Rationalism:** Social institutions could be explained through reason. **Example:** A law could be examined for its social consequences.
- **Positivism:** Society could be studied through systematic observation and regularities. **Example:** A researcher measures crime rates and compares social conditions.

Political transformation

- **French Revolution:** Challenged monarchy and feudal privilege. **Example:** Citizens and rights replaced hereditary estates as central political ideas.
- **Citizenship:** People were recognised as members with rights and duties. **Example:** A citizen could claim participation in public decisions.
- **Democracy:** Popular participation and representation gained importance. **Example:** Government became accountable to an electorate.
- **Nation-state:** Political authority was organised through a common territory, administration and citizenship. **Example:** A central state applied common law and taxation across regions.

Economic transformation

- **Commercial Revolution:** Markets, trade, credit and merchants expanded. **Example:** Overseas trade connected local producers to wider markets.
- **Capitalism:** Private property, profit and investment shaped production. **Example:** Capital was reinvested to enlarge a commercial enterprise.

- **Industrial Revolution:** Factories, machines, wage labour and urbanisation transformed work. **Example:** A mill town developed around industrial employment.

Social transformation

- **Urbanisation:** People moved to cities and encountered new social relationships. **Example:** Migrant workers lived among strangers and relied on formal services.
- **Class formation:** Bourgeoisie, proletariat and middle classes emerged. **Example:** Ownership and wage labour became major sources of social division.
- **Mobility:** Education and occupation provided new routes to movement. **Example:** A person could migrate and acquire a new professional status.
- **Family change:** Workplace, residence and family functions were reorganised. **Example:** Education moved partly from family to school.
- **Labour reorganisation:** Work became specialised, timed and supervised. **Example:** A factory worker performed one task under a formal shift system.
- **Secularisation:** Religion lost its exclusive control over law, politics, economy and education. **Example:** Public policy was justified through constitutional and administrative reasoning.

The flowchart in the updated material similarly connects industrial-market society, urban and class inequalities, political democratisation, scientific orientation, questioning of traditional beliefs and intellectual curiosity with the emergence of sociology.

Simple integrated example

The Industrial Revolution creates factories. Factories attract migrants and produce cities. Cities create class inequality, overcrowding and new forms of crime. The French Revolution and Enlightenment provide the language of rights and citizenship. Scientific thinking provides a method for studying the new problems. Sociology develops at the point where these intellectual and structural changes meet.

Why Modernity First Emerged in Europe

The question does not have one simple answer. Classical sociology identified a set of developments that appeared in a distinctive combination in Western Europe, while contemporary sociology also reminds us that the story should not become Eurocentric.

Rationalisation

Weber emphasised distinctive forms of rationality expressed through bureaucracy, formal law, administration and capitalist organisation.

Example: A modern public office selects officials through qualifications, written rules and predictable procedures rather than through personal loyalty or hereditary status.

Scientific Revolution

The Scientific Revolution gave greater importance to the sovereign, rational individual who could observe, calculate and question inherited knowledge.

Example: An astronomer could challenge an established cosmology through observation and mathematical reasoning.

Nation-state

Political authority increasingly shifted from divine authority towards popular sovereignty. The state claimed to represent a territorial population of citizens.

Example: A national government makes common laws, collects taxes and provides administration across a defined territory.

Secularisation

Different social spheres became more differentiated: religion, economy, politics and family gradually developed more independent institutional roles.

Example: Economic exchange can be organised through markets and contracts even though traders may follow different religious beliefs.

Division of labour

Durkheim associated modern transformation with the movement from mechanical solidarity to organic solidarity. People became different in their occupations but more dependent on one another.

Example: A modern city needs farmers, transport workers, doctors, teachers, engineers and administrators who perform separate but connected functions.

These developments help explain why sociology first took shape in Europe. However, they must be understood as a historically specific combination, not as proof that Europe possessed the only path to modernity.

Weber and Western Rationality

For **Max Weber**, modern Western society increasingly institutionalised rationality through bureaucratic organisations, formal legal systems, capitalist calculation and administrative control.

- **Bureaucratic organisations:** Offices have defined duties, hierarchy, records and rules. **Example:** A civil service department processes applications through officials assigned to specific responsibilities.
- **Formal legal systems:** Laws are written, general and applied through recognised procedures. **Example:** A court uses codified law and evidence rather than the personal mood of a ruler.
- **Capitalist calculation:** Profit, cost, risk and return are systematically calculated. **Example:** A company compares the cost of labour, raw material and transport before deciding where to produce.
- **Administrative control:** Large populations and organisations are governed through files, statistics and procedures. **Example:** A state uses population records and budgets to plan public services.

Modernity therefore does not simply mean “technology.” It means the increasing organisation of social life according to:

Calculation + Efficiency + Predictability + Rules

Critical point

Rationalisation increases efficiency, but it may also reduce autonomy.

Greater rational organisation ↔ Greater bureaucratic control

Example: An online welfare system can deliver benefits quickly through standard rules, but an algorithm may reject a genuine claimant who does not fit the standard data pattern. Efficiency can therefore coexist with loss of human discretion.

Weber's concern is not that rules are always bad. His point is that the spread of formal rationality can trap people in systems that are efficient but impersonal and difficult to challenge.

Secularisation

Modernisation increased differentiation between social institutions. Religion became less able to monopolise politics, economy, education, law and science.

- **Politics:** Political authority could be justified through constitutions and citizenship. **Example:** A government claims legitimacy through elections rather than only through divine right.
- **Economy:** Markets and contracts became relatively independent of religious control. **Example:** A business relationship may be governed by commercial law between people of different faiths.
- **Education:** Schools and universities developed independent curricula and methods. **Example:** Science is taught through observation and experiment rather than through one religious authority alone.
- **Law:** Legal systems became more formal and state-based. **Example:** A court uses written civil and criminal law applicable to citizens as legal persons.
- **Science:** Natural phenomena are explained through testable principles. **Example:** Disease is studied through biology and public health rather than only through supernatural explanations.

Secularisation does not necessarily mean the disappearance of religion. It means a changing relationship between religion and other institutions, especially the loss of an exclusive religious monopoly.

Contemporary critique

Modernisation does not automatically eliminate religion. Religion continues to remain socially and politically significant in many advanced modern societies.

Example: A highly industrialised and technologically advanced country may still have strong religious organisations, public religious debates or faith-based political movements.

Therefore:

Modernity ≠ Complete secular disappearance of religion

The sociological question is how religion changes, adapts and interacts with modern institutions.

Modernity Beyond Europe

Classical accounts sometimes presented European modernity as universal, internally generated and a model that every society would eventually copy. Contemporary sociology challenges this assumption.

The European experience was historically important, but it was not isolated from the wider world. Modern institutions have been adopted, imposed, negotiated and reshaped in different societies.

Example: Modern law, education and bureaucracy entered many colonised societies through imperial rule, but local communities adapted them to their own languages, social structures and political struggles.

The central lesson is that modernity should be studied as a set of institutional processes with different historical forms, not as a single cultural package called “the West.”

Shmuel Eisenstadt - Multiple Modernities

Shmuel Eisenstadt argued that modernity can take multiple forms. Different societies combine modern institutions with their own cultural traditions, civilisational histories, religious arrangements and institutional patterns.

Thus, there is not necessarily one single modernity. There can be:

Multiple modernities

The idea does not deny common modern processes such as bureaucratisation, industrialisation or mass education. It says that these processes are interpreted and organised differently in different civilisations.

Example: Democracy may coexist with different family systems, religious traditions and community institutions in India, Japan, Europe or the Middle East.

Example: India

India demonstrates coexistence of:

- **Democratic institutions:** Elections, legislatures and constitutional rights organise political life.
Example: Citizens choose representatives even though caste, religion and kinship continue to influence voting behaviour.
- **Modern bureaucracy:** Administrative offices operate through formal rules and public authority.
Example: A citizen applies for a certificate through a government procedure.
- **Capitalist economy:** Markets, private enterprise and investment shape production. **Example:** Start-ups and companies use capital, technology and markets to expand.
- **Digital technology:** Mobile phones, digital payments and online platforms connect people to services. **Example:** A small trader can receive digital payments and sell beyond the local neighbourhood.

These coexist with:

- **Caste:** Caste identities can influence marriage, networks and political mobilisation. **Example:** A modern educated person may still prefer an endogamous marriage.
- **Kinship:** Family and kin networks continue to provide support and social identity. **Example:** Relatives may help with employment, marriage or migration.

- **Arranged/endogamous marriage:** Marriage may combine modern education and online communication with selection within a community. **Example:** Families use digital matrimonial platforms but search for a partner within caste or religious boundaries.
- **Religion:** Religious beliefs and institutions remain part of public and private life. **Example:** A professional working in a modern city may also participate in religious festivals and organisations.
- **Traditional community identities:** Local and community identities can shape social relationships. **Example:** A migrant may use a regional association in a city for support.

Therefore, tradition and modernity can coexist rather than simply replace each other.

Exam-quality line

Modernity does not necessarily destroy tradition; it may reconstruct and recombine tradition within modern institutions.

Colonialism and Modernity

Modernity outside Europe was not always an autonomous internal development. Colonial expansion transmitted modern bureaucracy, education, capitalist markets, modern law and state structures, but often under conditions of political domination, economic extraction and cultural hierarchy.

- **Modern bureaucracy:** Colonial administrations created records, departments, police and revenue systems. **Example:** Land surveys and revenue offices increased administrative control over local communities.
- **Education:** Modern schools and universities spread new knowledge but could also serve colonial administrative needs. **Example:** English education produced a new educated group while privileging colonial language and institutions.
- **Capitalist markets:** Local production was linked to imperial trade. **Example:** Farmers could be encouraged or compelled to produce commodities for external markets.
- **Modern law:** Codified laws and courts replaced or reorganised many local arrangements. **Example:** A colonial court applied uniform rules while also placing local institutions under imperial authority.
- **State structures:** Centralised administration and territorial control expanded. **Example:** The colonial state collected taxes and governed distant regions through officials and police.

These changes were contradictory. They introduced institutions later used by anti-colonial movements, but they were originally embedded in unequal power relations.

Example: Educated colonised groups used modern ideas of rights, citizenship and nationalism to challenge the very colonial authority that had introduced some modern institutions.

Aníbal Quijano - Coloniality of Modernity

Aníbal Quijano challenges narratives in which European modernity appears to have been produced purely within Europe. European modernity was connected with colonial labour, resources, markets and non-European societies.

Meaning of coloniality

Colonialism may formally end, but patterns of power, knowledge, race and economic inequality created during colonial rule can continue. This continuing structure is referred to as **coloniality**.

Example: A formerly colonised economy may continue to export raw materials, depend on external technology and treat Western knowledge as the universal standard even after political independence.

European modernity was connected with:

- **Colonial labour:** Labour from colonised societies supported imperial production. **Example:** Plantation or mining systems used controlled and unequal labour.
- **Resources:** Raw materials and natural wealth were integrated into European accumulation. **Example:** Colonial territories supplied agricultural or mineral resources to imperial industries.
- **Markets:** Colonised populations became markets for finished products. **Example:** Locally produced goods could be displaced by imported manufactured goods.
- **Non-European societies:** The development of Europe cannot be separated from its relationships with Asia, Africa and the Americas. **Example:** European industrial growth and overseas political power developed together.

Critical use

Europe did not become “modern” in complete isolation. European modernity was partly constituted through its global colonial relationships.

Gurminder K. Bhambra - Connected Sociologies

Gurminder Bhambra criticises classical accounts of sociology for treating Europe as the universal norm while marginalising colonial encounters, non-European histories and global interconnections.

Connected sociologies

Societies should not be treated as separate containers developing independently. Their histories are connected through trade, empire, migration, slavery, knowledge exchange and political domination.

Example: The industrial development of Europe and the economic restructuring of colonies should be studied together because they were connected through raw materials, markets and imperial power.

Bhambra's perspective asks sociology to include the voices and histories that a Europe-only story leaves out.

2024 critical examination value

If the question says:

“Sociology is the product of European Enlightenment and Renaissance. Critically examine.”

Bhambra and Quijano provide advanced criticism:

The conventional narrative risks presenting modernity as a purely **European, internally generated phenomenon**, while ignoring colonial and global connections.

Example of answer use: After explaining Enlightenment and Renaissance, add that the circulation of resources, labour and knowledge through colonial relationships also shaped modern Europe and the modern world.

Anthony Giddens - Reflexive Modernity

For **Anthony Giddens**, modernity is not a completed or static condition. It is **reflexive**. Modern institutions continually produce knowledge, re-evaluate themselves, modify behaviour and reorganise institutions.

Meaning of reflexivity

Modern society collects information about its own working and then uses that information to change itself.

Example: A government studies traffic data, changes transport policy, observes the results and changes the policy again.

Modernity therefore continually transforms itself, particularly under globalisation and technological change.

Simple feedback example

- Technology changes work. **Example:** Online platforms introduce app-based delivery work.
- Research shows new problems of technology. **Example:** Studies identify insecurity, long working hours or privacy concerns.
- Governments regulate technology. **Example:** New rules may address data protection or worker rights.
- Companies modify technology. **Example:** The platform changes its payment, safety or privacy system.
- Society adapts again. **Example:** Workers, consumers and institutions learn new practices, creating fresh questions.

This continuous feedback illustrates **reflexivity**.

Modernity and Contemporary Technology

The **Digital Revolution** is a new phase of modernity. Modern rationalisation increasingly enters algorithmic governance, data surveillance, online platforms and platform capitalism.

- **Algorithmic governance:** Decisions are partly made or guided by data systems and algorithms. **Example:** An online system may rank applications, allocate services or identify risk through programmed criteria.
- **Data surveillance:** Everyday activities generate information that organisations can monitor and analyse. **Example:** A phone application may record location, searches and purchasing behaviour.
- **Online platforms:** Digital companies organise interaction, work, consumption and communication. **Example:** A platform connects customers with drivers, delivery workers or sellers.
- **Platform capitalism:** Companies control digital infrastructures and earn profit by organising users, data and transactions. **Example:** A platform may not produce the good itself but controls the market through its app, payment system and ratings.

These developments produce new tensions between:

Autonomy and control

People receive convenience, flexibility and access, but decisions may increasingly be shaped by invisible data systems.

Example: A gig worker can choose when to log in, yet an algorithm may influence income through ratings, incentives and task allocation.

Classical and contemporary parallels

Classical modernity	Contemporary manifestation	Simple example
Factory controlled worker	Digital platform/algorithm can organise worker	A delivery app allocates tasks and tracks performance.
Bureaucratic file	Database and algorithmic decision	A digital system evaluates eligibility through stored data.
Industrial capitalism	Platform capitalism	A company profits by controlling the digital marketplace.

Weber's rationalisation and Marx's analysis of control over production therefore remain highly relevant. The factory supervisor may be replaced by software, but questions of control, dependence and surplus remain.

Modernity and Right-Wing / Identity Politics

Contemporary Europe shows tensions between universal liberal ideals, cultural identity, nationalism and resurgent identity politics.

- **Universal liberal ideals:** Modern political thought speaks of equal rights and citizenship. **Example:** Every citizen is formally entitled to equal legal protection.
- **Cultural identity:** People continue to attach importance to language, religion, history and lifestyle. **Example:** A community may demand recognition of its cultural traditions.
- **Nationalism:** Political belonging may be defined through the nation and territorial community. **Example:** Citizens may support policies that prioritise national control over global institutions.
- **Resurgent identity politics:** Groups mobilise around perceived threats to their culture, religion or economic position. **Example:** Political campaigns may use immigration or national identity to create a strong “us” and “them.”

This demonstrates that modernisation does not necessarily produce a simple linear movement towards complete cosmopolitanism, complete secularism or the disappearance of collective identities.

Critical line

Modernity produces **individualisation**, but can simultaneously intensify collective identities based on:

Nation + Ethnicity + Religion + Culture

Example: A person may enjoy an individual career and digital lifestyle while also strongly identifying with a nation, religious group or ethnic community.

Sociology in the United States - Social Reformist Orientation

The proposition that sociology emerged in Europe but initially flourished in the USA with a social-reform orientation becomes clearer when we examine the American context.

American sociology developed in a setting marked by:

- **Rapid industrialisation:** Factories, corporations and wage labour expanded. **Example:** Industrial cities attracted workers and produced problems of labour relations.
- **Mass immigration:** People from different countries entered American cities. **Example:** Immigrant neighbourhoods developed their own languages, institutions and patterns of adaptation.
- **Labour unrest:** Workers protested against low wages, long hours and unsafe work. **Example:** Strikes forced public debate about labour rights.
- **Racial segregation:** Racial hierarchy shaped housing, schooling, work and citizenship. **Example:** Segregated neighbourhoods and unequal public services became subjects of research.
- **Urban problems:** Cities faced poverty, crime, overcrowding and social disorganisation. **Example:** A rapidly growing city required studies of neighbourhoods, migration and public health.

Sociology therefore became strongly connected with social reform, empirical research and public policy.

Example: A sociologist might study an immigrant settlement not only to develop a theory but also to recommend housing, education or health reforms.

Chicago School

The **Chicago School of Sociology** played a major role in early American sociology. Its researchers treated the city as a social laboratory and studied social processes in their actual settings.

Its major concerns included:

- **City life:** How urban living changes relationships and behaviour. **Example:** People interact with many strangers and move through specialised spaces.
- **Immigration:** How newcomers adjust, form communities and experience discrimination. **Example:** Migrants may create ethnic neighbourhoods that provide support while also facing exclusion.
- **Crime:** How crime relates to neighbourhood conditions and social control. **Example:** Crime patterns may differ between stable and rapidly changing localities.

- **Neighbourhoods:** How space and local institutions shape social life. **Example:** The presence of schools, parks and community associations affects local cohesion.
- **Community:** How collective bonds are formed or weakened in cities. **Example:** A neighbourhood association can provide support when traditional kinship is absent.
- **Urban ecology:** How groups compete, adapt and occupy different social spaces. **Example:** Commercial centres, immigrant settlements and elite residential areas may develop distinct zones.
- **Social disorganisation:** How rapid change weakens norms and institutions. **Example:** High population turnover can reduce informal social control.

American sociology thus combined theory with field research, observation and reform.

Robert Park - Human Ecology

Robert Park analysed urban life through competition, migration, segregation, human ecology and social disorganisation. He treated the city as a **social laboratory**.

- **Competition:** Groups compete for land, jobs and resources. **Example:** Different businesses compete for central commercial space, while households compete for affordable housing.
- **Migration:** The movement of people changes neighbourhoods and institutions. **Example:** New migrants may create markets, associations and places of worship in the city.
- **Segregation:** Groups may be separated by race, class, ethnicity or income. **Example:** Poor and wealthy households may live in different parts of the city with unequal access to services.
- **Human ecology:** Social groups occupy, adapt to and transform urban spaces. **Example:** A neighbourhood may change from an industrial area to a residential or commercial area.
- **Social disorganisation:** Rapid turnover and weak institutions may reduce shared norms. **Example:** A locality with unstable housing and few community organisations may struggle to control crime.

The city becomes a laboratory because a researcher can observe migration, competition, cooperation and conflict in visible spatial forms.

Ernest Burgess - Concentric Zone Model

E. W. Burgess examined the spatial growth of cities through a concentric-zone approach. The model attempted to explain urban expansion, spatial differentiation, community organisation and social problems.

In simple terms, the city was imagined as expanding outward in zones. The central business area could be surrounded by transitional areas, working-class neighbourhoods and more stable residential areas.

- **Urban expansion:** Cities grow outward as population and economic activity increase. **Example:** New housing and industries develop beyond the old city centre.
- **Spatial differentiation:** Different social groups and activities occupy different areas. **Example:** Offices concentrate in the centre while factories and residential colonies may lie elsewhere.
- **Community organisation:** Neighbourhoods develop their own institutions and identities. **Example:** A migrant settlement may have shops, associations and religious institutions serving its residents.
- **Social problems:** Transitional or neglected areas may experience overcrowding, poverty and crime. **Example:** Rapid population turnover can weaken local control and public services.

The model is useful as a starting point for studying the relationship between urban space and social life, although real cities do not always follow neat concentric circles.

Jane Addams - Sociology and Reform

Jane Addams, associated with **Hull House**, represents the reform-oriented dimension of early American sociology. Her work engaged with poverty, women's issues, education and labour conditions.

- **Poverty:** Hull House worked with poor urban communities and helped reveal the social causes of deprivation. **Example:** Settlement workers could identify problems of rent, sanitation, food and insecure employment.
- **Women's issues:** Women's work, safety and political voice became subjects of public action. **Example:** Reformers could support better working conditions and greater participation for women.
- **Education:** Education was used to expand opportunities for immigrant and working-class communities. **Example:** A settlement house could provide classes, libraries or training.
- **Labour conditions:** Long hours and unsafe work were connected with the need for labour reform. **Example:** Evidence from workers' lives could support demands for factory regulation.

American sociology therefore developed not merely as abstract theory but also as **applied social inquiry**.

Direct PYQ - 2013

UPSC asks about the proposition that sociology emerged in Europe but initially flourished in the USA with a social-reform orientation.

Part 1 - Why Europe?

Use Renaissance, Enlightenment, French Revolution, Industrial Revolution and capitalism.

Example: Europe experienced the intellectual questioning and structural upheavals that first made a scientific study of society necessary.

Part 2 - Why USA?

Use industrialisation, immigration, urbanisation, race relations and labour problems.

Example: American cities offered visible and urgent problems that could be studied through field research.

Part 3 - Reform orientation

Use Chicago School, social surveys, Jane Addams and applied sociology.

Example: Research was connected with practical recommendations on housing, education, crime and labour.

This is stronger than writing only that sociology started in Europe and later moved to America.

Sociology as the Study of Modern Society

The 2016 PYQ asks: "Sociology is pre-eminently the study of modern societies." Discuss.

The statement is largely valid because classical sociology emerged to understand the major processes of modernity.

- **Capitalism:** Marx studied ownership, class relations and exploitation. **Example:** The relationship between factory owners and wage labourers shows how capitalism structures social life.
- **Urbanisation:** Chicago sociologists examined migration, neighbourhoods and social disorganisation. **Example:** A city becomes a setting where new forms of social interaction and conflict can be observed.
- **Industrialisation:** Sociologists examined factories, division of labour and class formation. **Example:** Mechanised production changes occupation, time discipline and family life.
- **Bureaucracy:** Weber studied formal organisation, rules and authority. **Example:** Government offices coordinate large populations through files and procedures.
- **Secularisation:** Modern institutions became differentiated from religious authority. **Example:** Law and science claim independent bases of legitimacy.
- **Democracy:** Citizenship, representation and popular sovereignty became central. **Example:** Political participation is organised through elections and rights.

- **Individualism:** Individuals became rights-bearing and mobile persons. **Example:** Education and occupation allow people to make choices beyond inherited status.
- **Social mobility:** Modern society creates new routes through education, skills and occupation. **Example:** A person can move from a rural background into a professional role.
- **Modern nation-state:** The state governs a territorial population through common laws and administration. **Example:** Citizens are connected through national institutions even when they belong to different communities.

Thinker mapping

- **Marx:** Capitalism and class relations. **Example:** Class position is linked to ownership of the means of production.
- **Durkheim:** Division of labour, solidarity and anomie. **Example:** Specialisation increases interdependence but weak regulation can produce normlessness.
- **Weber:** Rationalisation and bureaucracy. **Example:** Modern life is increasingly organised through calculation and formal rules.
- **Simmel:** Modern urban life and changing social interaction. **Example:** The city exposes individuals to many brief, impersonal encounters and a fast pace of life.

Critical part

Sociology is not only the study of industrial Western societies. Contemporary sociology also studies tribe, village, religion, kinship, caste, indigenous society and the traditional-modern interface.

Example: A sociologist may study how caste operates in a modern electoral democracy or how kinship adapts to migration and digital communication.

Therefore:

Sociology originated primarily from the problems of modernity but subsequently developed into the systematic study of social relations in diverse societies.

Modernity: Emancipation vs Domination

A strong sociology answer should avoid describing modernity only as “progress.” Modernity contains contradictions: the same institution can enlarge human possibilities and create new forms of control.

Emancipatory side	Critical side	Example
Rationality	Instrumental rationality	Scientific planning can improve public health, but people may be treated only as numbers or targets.

Emancipatory side	Critical side	Example
Democracy	Bureaucratic domination	Citizens gain voting rights, but complex offices may make decisions difficult to challenge.
Individual freedom	Social isolation	People choose their education and occupation, but may lose close community support.
Capitalism	Class exploitation	Markets create employment and goods, but workers may receive an unequal share of value.
Industrial productivity	Alienation	Machines increase output, but repetitive work can separate workers from the meaning of production.
Urbanisation	Slums and disorganisation	Cities provide jobs and services, but rapid growth may create overcrowded settlements.
Science	Technological control	Technology cures disease, but data and surveillance can monitor behaviour.
Mobility	Persistent inequality	Education and migration open opportunities, but class, gender and cultural capital affect access.
Secularism	Value conflicts	Common civic law can unite citizens, but public disagreement over values may continue.
Digitalisation	Surveillance	Digital services are convenient, but platforms collect personal data.
Globalisation	Unequal integration	Global markets connect producers and consumers, but benefits and risks are distributed unevenly.

Explanation of the central idea

Modernity creates freedom from some old forms of domination, but it may create new domination through capital, bureaucracy, technology and data. This is the essence of a **critical sociology of modernity**.

Example: A digital welfare system may reduce corruption through transparent records and at the same time exclude a person whose biometric or database information is incorrect. The same rational system can empower and control.

Modernity is Not Equal to Westernisation

This distinction is essential for Sociology Optional.

Westernisation

Westernisation means the imitation or adoption of Western cultural patterns, such as dress, food, language, lifestyles or institutional forms.

Example: A society may adopt Western clothing, English-language education or a corporate lifestyle without transforming all its social institutions.

Modernisation

Modernisation is a broader structural transformation involving differentiation, industrialisation, rationalisation, urbanisation, bureaucratisation and political participation.

- **Differentiation:** Institutions become specialised. **Example:** Education, health care, law and religion operate through partly separate organisations.
- **Industrialisation:** Production uses machines, factories and technical organisation. **Example:** Employment shifts from only farming to manufacturing and services.
- **Rationalisation:** Rules, calculation and efficiency guide institutions. **Example:** A public office uses written procedures and records.
- **Urbanisation:** Population and economic activity become concentrated in towns and cities. **Example:** Rural migrants move to cities for jobs.
- **Bureaucratisation:** Administration is organised through offices, hierarchy and formal rules. **Example:** Government departments process citizens' applications through standard procedures.
- **Political participation:** Citizens participate in elections, public debate and representative institutions. **Example:** People vote, organise associations and demand accountability.

A society can modernise while preserving significant cultural traditions. Modernisation is therefore not identical to copying Western culture.

Example: India uses constitutional democracy, modern bureaucracy, capitalism and digital technology while retaining caste, kinship, religion and local community identities. This connects directly to multiple modernities.

Tradition vs Modernity: Do Not Treat Them as Binary

Older modernisation theories often implied:

More Modernity = Less Tradition

Contemporary sociology questions this simple binary. Tradition can adapt, reinvent itself, use modern technology, enter democratic politics and operate through market institutions.

- **Tradition can adapt:** A customary institution may change its rules while retaining its identity. **Example:** A community organisation may use online meetings and digital records.
- **Tradition can reinvent itself:** Old symbols can receive new meanings in modern settings. **Example:** A festival may become both a religious event and a public cultural programme.

- **Tradition can use modern technology:** Traditional practices can be organised through digital tools. **Example:** Families use online platforms to search for marriage partners within a community.
- **Tradition can enter democratic politics:** Community identities may become bases of representation and mobilisation. **Example:** A caste or ethnic association may campaign during elections.
- **Tradition can operate through market institutions:** Customary preferences may be expressed through modern commercial services. **Example:** A matrimonial website enables endogamous marriage through a market-based digital service.

Indian example: caste and modernity

Caste may coexist with electoral democracy, urbanisation, higher education and digital matrimonial platforms.

Example: A highly educated urban person may compete in a modern labour market, vote in a democratic election and use a smartphone, while still preferring an endogamous marriage and caste-based social network.

Modern structures may therefore reshape tradition rather than simply destroy it.

Contemporary Sociology of Modernity

The classical processes of modernity continue in new forms.

Classical modernity	Contemporary manifestation	Explanation and example
Industrialisation	AI, automation and robotics	Machines now perform not only physical work but also selected cognitive and decision-support tasks.
Factory capitalism	Platform capitalism	Digital platforms organise transactions and earn profit without looking like traditional factories.
Wage labour	Gig/platform labour	Workers receive tasks through apps and may face flexible but insecure employment.
Bureaucracy	Algorithmic governance	Rules are implemented through databases and automated systems.
Urbanisation	Megacities	Cities have expanded into large metropolitan regions with complex transport and housing problems.
Surveillance by organisation	Data surveillance	Digital traces allow companies and states to monitor behaviour at a large scale.
Mass media	Social media platforms	Communication is faster and more interactive but can also spread misinformation and polarisation.
Occupational division	Knowledge economy	Work is increasingly divided around information, data, design and specialised expertise.
Market expansion	Global digital markets	A seller can reach customers in distant locations through an online platform.

Classical modernity	Contemporary manifestation	Explanation and example
Rationalisation	Datafication	Activities are converted into measurable data for calculation and prediction.
Individualism	Networked individualism	Individuals make choices independently but remain connected through digital networks.
Colonial connections	Global inequalities	Old and new economic relationships connect countries unequally through finance, technology, labour and trade.

Example: A food-delivery platform shows several transformations together: urbanisation creates demand, digital technology allocates tasks, gig labour provides workers, datafication measures performance and platform capitalism captures value.

Thinkers' Corner - Modernity in One Line

Auguste Comte

Modernity created a crisis of social order requiring a scientific science of society.

Example: New institutions need systematic knowledge to manage conflict and create stability.

Karl Marx

Modernity is fundamentally shaped by **capitalism, class conflict and exploitation**.

Example: The ownership of factories separates capitalists from workers and creates conflicting interests.

Émile Durkheim

Modernity involves increasing **division of labour**, movement towards organic solidarity and the risk of anomie.

Example: Specialised occupations make people interdependent, but rapid change can weaken common norms.

Max Weber

Modernity is characterised by **rationalisation, capitalism and bureaucratisation**.

Example: Banks, offices and companies use calculation, written rules and predictable procedures.

Herbert Spencer

Modernity involves increasing social differentiation and functional interdependence.

Example: Family, economy, religion and politics become distinct but connected institutions.

Anthony Giddens

Modernity is **reflexive** and continuously reconstitutes itself.

Example: New technology changes society, research identifies new risks and institutions modify their behaviour.

Shmuel Eisenstadt

There is not one modernity but **multiple modernities**.

Example: India combines democracy and digital technology with caste, kinship and religion.

Aníbal Quijano

European modernity is inseparable from **coloniality**.

Example: European accumulation and modern institutions were connected with colonial labour, resources and markets.

Gurminder Bhambra

Modernity should be understood through **connected global histories**, not a Europe-only narrative.

Example: European industrial development and colonial economic restructuring must be studied as connected processes.